

Teresa Amabile

The Componential Model & the Social Psychology of Creativity

b. 1950 · Edsel Bryant Ford Professor Emerita · Harvard Business School

[portrait]
Teresa Amabile

1 WHY THIS THINKER MATTERS

How do you get more creativity out of the people you already have? Amabile answers the manager's real question: creativity is not a fixed gift but a variable you can raise or crush through the work environment you design. Her research is where creativity stops being mystical and becomes manageable.

2 INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

American social psychologist. Professor Emerita at Harvard Business School, formerly at Brandeis. She pioneered the experimental study of creativity in real organisational settings and, with Steven Kramer, the large-scale diary study behind the 'progress principle'.

"You can kill creativity far more easily than you can build it."

"Of all the things that can boost inner work life, the most important is making progress in meaningful work."

3 FRAMEWORKS · TOOLS · MODELS

NAME	WHAT IT IS
Componential Model	Expertise × creative-thinking skills × intrinsic motivation
Intrinsic Motivation Principle	People are most creative when driven by interest, not pressure
Creativity-killers	Surveillance, harsh evaluation, over-control, competition
The Progress Principle	Small wins in meaningful work fuel inner work life
Componential Theory of Org. Creativity	Environment amplifies or suppresses the three components

4 HOW IT'S OPERATIONALIZED

- Diagnose which component (expertise, skills, motivation) limits a team
- Audit the environment for creativity-killers before blaming people
- Protect intrinsic motivation from the wrong incentives and surveillance
- Design for daily progress on meaningful work, not just outcomes
- Match rewards to the type of task to avoid crowding out interest

6 ENDURING IMPACT

- Foundational reference for creativity management
- 'How to Kill Creativity' among HBR's most-cited creativity articles
- Shifted the field from the genius to the environment

5 LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUES

- Intrinsic-motivation emphasis debated for highly extrinsic contexts
- Componential model is descriptive, not strongly predictive
- Much early evidence from lab and student tasks
- Less guidance on team- vs individual-level dynamics
- Cultural generalisability of motivation findings contested

SELECTED WORKS

CREATIVITY IN CONTEXT
Update to the Social Psychology of Creativity

AMABILE · 1996

THE PROGRESS PRINCIPLE
with Steven Kramer

AMABILE · 2011

HOW TO KILL CREATIVITY
Harvard Business Review

AMABILE · 1998

THE SOCIAL PSYCHOLOGY OF CREATIVITY
Springer

AMABILE · 1983

REFERENCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Amabile, T.M. (1998) 'How to Kill Creativity', *Harvard Business Review*, 76(5), pp. 76–87.